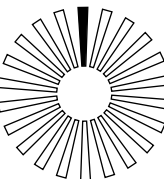


Gamified fitness app

From UX to Branding — a full-scope case study



Type: mobile app
Scope: UX Research, Product Strategy,
UI & Visual Design, Prototyping & Motion, Usability Testing



The challenge

“This project was born out of frustration — mine and my friends”

At some point, I decided it was time to take better care of myself — get in shape, be healthier. I tried a bunch of fitness apps, but none of them kept me hooked for long. I’d open them, click through the onboarding, check a few stats... and forget about them in just few days.

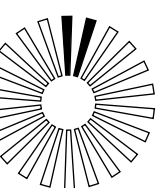
After talking to some friends, it turned out I wasn’t alone. Many people want to take care of themselves, but they often say things like: “these apps feel too technical”, “they’re not fun” or “they make me feel pressured instead of supported”.

Then I remembered how, back in school, I could spend hours playing computer games — no plan, no pressure. Just pure flow and the joy of doing something engaging.

That became the spark for creating Dinamove — an app that combines gamification with a holistic approach to a healthy lifestyle.

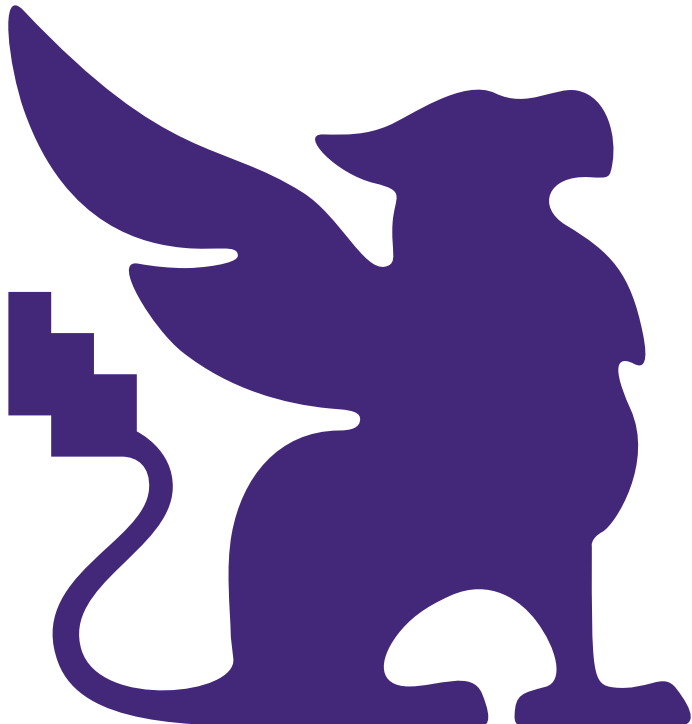
Dinamove isn’t just about points and levels. It’s a complete ecosystem with personalized workout plans, running and training assistant, nutrition tracking, and a supportive community.

The project was part of my master’s thesis — but from the start, I treated it as a real experiment. The goal was to design an experience that’s as engaging as a game, but as supportive as this "gym bro" figure. An app that doesn’t judge, but motivates — one that sees the user not as a performance machine, but as a person with their own rhythm, style and needs.



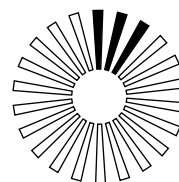
What's out there — and what's missing?

Before I even started sketching the first screens, I wanted to make sure Dinamove wouldn't end up as just another fitness app. So I took a look at what's already on the market — and how it actually works.

Strava	Fitatu	Habitica	Duolingo	Nike Training Club
				
 strong community, leaderboards, running tracking	 large food database, calorie tracking, solid functionality	 creative RPG-style gamification, tasks as quests	 strong gamification: XP, streaks, leagues, buddy system	 professional video workouts, clean minimal UI
 mostly for advanced users, focused only on running	 dry tone of voice, no emotional support, cold UI	 low usability, not really fitness-oriented	 high pressure, not fitness-related	 rigid plans, no gamification, little personalization

When I realized the competition didn't quite address the problems I had identified, I decided to talk to users. I wanted to find out whether they felt those problems too.

"Checked what's on the market" → "Didn't buy it" → "Talked to people"



Reality check

“Is it just me or what?”

After analyzing the competition, I had a hunch. Many fitness apps offer great features — but they fall short in other areas. I wanted to find out whether this was just my personal take, or a broader issue.

market products critique + people's observations = fuller picture

So I ran both quantitative and qualitative research: an online survey and in-depth interviews. The goal wasn't to prove my assumptions at all costs, but to confront them with real user experiences.



Research setup

Survey:

- 123 respondents
- 23 questions + 1 open-ended
- open group
- via Google Forms

Interviews:

- 15 participants
- 25-35 min each
- purposive sampling (based on research + survey results)
- in person or via Zoom / Teams



Most important insights

Hard data:

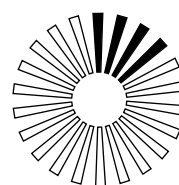
- 92,9% of respondents who rarely exercise pointed to lack of motivation as the main barrier — alongside fatigue and lack of time.
- 65% had positive experiences with companion mascots in apps.
- 76,4% responded positively to gamification elements.

Findings and observations:

- Points and rewards are welcome — but only when meaningful and balanced, otherwise they quickly lose appeal.
- Daily streak mechanics tend to create pressure rather than support.
- Many users mentioned that social features — like sharing progress and mutual encouragement — significantly boost their morale

Based on the research and interviews, I created three personas (one primary and two secondary) — each with unique goals and frustrations that guided design decisions.

They weren't based solely on quantitative data; they emerged largely as a distillation of qualitative insights gathered from the survey and conversations. This helped me structure my thinking about user types and their needs.



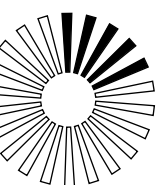
“Some things the app could just do automatically. During a workout, I don’t want to sit staring at my phone.”

“It should explain — in words or a short video — how to do exercises correctly. Show which muscles they target, and maybe give a short motivational intro!”

“I don’t want to use five different apps — I need something that covers everything, more or less.”

“I like gamification — earning levels and small rewards would be great. What frustrates me are bugs in location tracking that mess up my workout stats.”

“...clarity, simplicity, no pressure...”



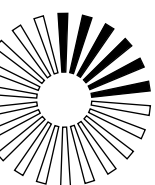
Houston, We Have a Problem

“I thought I’d just add points, streaks — a little game element and done. But something just didn’t feel right...”

In my original idea, streaks were supposed to be the foundation — daily logins, points, badges. It works in Duolingo, so why wouldn’t it work here?

I realized that streaks rely on what behavioral psychology calls negative reinforcement — a mechanism where we act to avoid an unpleasant stimulus. In this case: we open the app out of fear of breaking the streak, not out of genuine desire.

Sure, it can work in the short term. But in the long run, it can lead to frustration and burnout. And Dinamove is all about building positive associations — not forcing users.



Solving the Problem

What did I do about it?

A new idea emerged:

→ What if, instead of punishing a break, we rewarded the comeback?

Not continuity, but rebuilding. Not guilt, but appreciation. Instead of saying “you lost,” the app says:

“Glad you’re back. This is the moment that counts the most.”

That moment — returning after a break — is the hardest, but also the most important. So instead of punishing it, Dinamove celebrates the choice. This is where real change begins.

“Instead of weaving in negative reinforcement, I focused only on positive ones.”

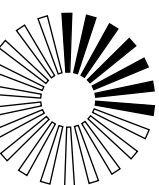
...and that’s where Dinamo steps in

Your digital buddy — not a coach, not a judge, but a companion on your health journey. It’s there when you come back, reminding you that every step counts.

Dinamo isn’t a mascot just for the sake of having one. It’s a symbol of a new tone of communication

“It’s not about what Dinamo says, but how it says it. It’s not the form, but the tone and intent of the communication that make the difference.”

Dinamo also allows for the implementation of additional gamification elements — the feedback already mentioned, and personalization, like customizing the avatar’s appearance.



Designing the Solution

Dinamove = more than just training

During the research, I realized that users aren't looking for a single feature that will "fix" them. They need a holistic system — one that supports them, motivates them, and helps them see real progress. That's how the five pillars of Dinamove were created — interconnected elements designed to support real, lasting change.



Activity

Running and an exercise assistant for instant workouts — cardio, strength, mobility.

For those who just want to get moving — here and now.



Training

Personalized programs adjusted by AI to your goals, level, and progress.

Like a trainer who learns together with you.



Community

Friends list and an activity feed inspired by social media — leagues and rankings.

You're not alone — together it's easier to stay consistent.



Diet

Smart meal journal and hydration tracker.

A balanced lifestyle. No miracle diets.

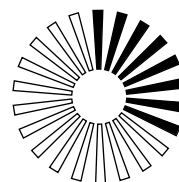


Progress

Key metrics: records, stats, week-to-week progress.

See your fitness grow — numbers don't lie.

The UI colors helps users understand which section they're currently in.



If not streaks — then what?

Gamification not as decoration, but as an engagement engine.

In Dinamove, every mechanism — points, levels, badges, community, or personalization — was designed for a reason. It’s not about “playing an app,” but about helping users feel progress, meaning, and real support in building habits.

Element	Role in the user experience
points (XP)	Clear rewards for actions; help build rhythm and habits.
levels	Show progress and provide a clear structure for growth.
badges	Acknowledge specific behaviors and achievements.
community	Strengthens the sense of belonging and support.
leaderboards	Healthy, optional competition that motivates better results without pressure.
personalization	Adjusting training plans to individual needs and goals.
feedback	Immediate feedback and motivation.
companion mascot	Emotional context and communication with the user.

Psychological foundations

Self-Determination Theory (Deci & Ryan)

Motivation emerges when three needs are met:

- autonomy — we want choice and a sense of control,
- competence — we need to see progress,
- relatedness — we want to feel part of a community.

Internal vs external motivation

Intrinsic motivation comes from acting out of one’s own will — e.g. when something helps us grow or brings joy. Extrinsic motivation is driven by rewards or pressure.

Dinamove rewards, but doesn’t create dependency. Its mechanisms support actions users want to take on their own.

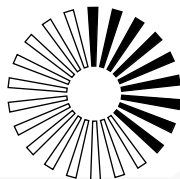
Positive reinforcement (Skinner)

Instead of punishment and pressure — rewards for desired behaviors. Instead of fear of losing a streak — praise for coming back, even after a break

In Dinamove, many micro-interactions follow a simple rule: “Do something good → get something pleasant.”

Social learning theory (Bandura)

We learn by observing others. aln Dinamove, you see friends’ activity, leaderboard positions, and community successes — supporting action through positive examples.



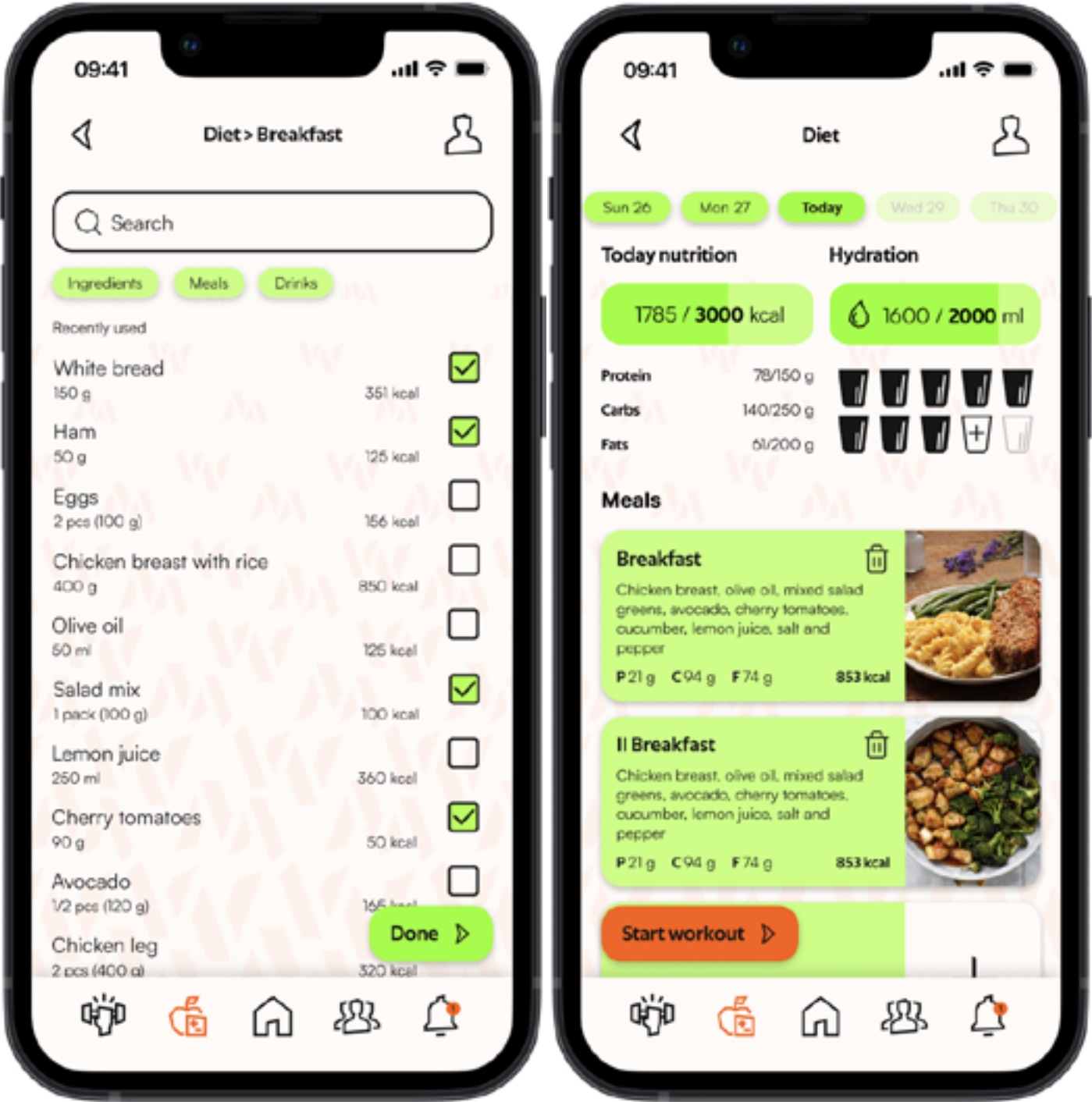
From Needs to Design

How research insights turned into specific features and app screens

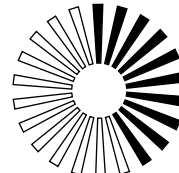
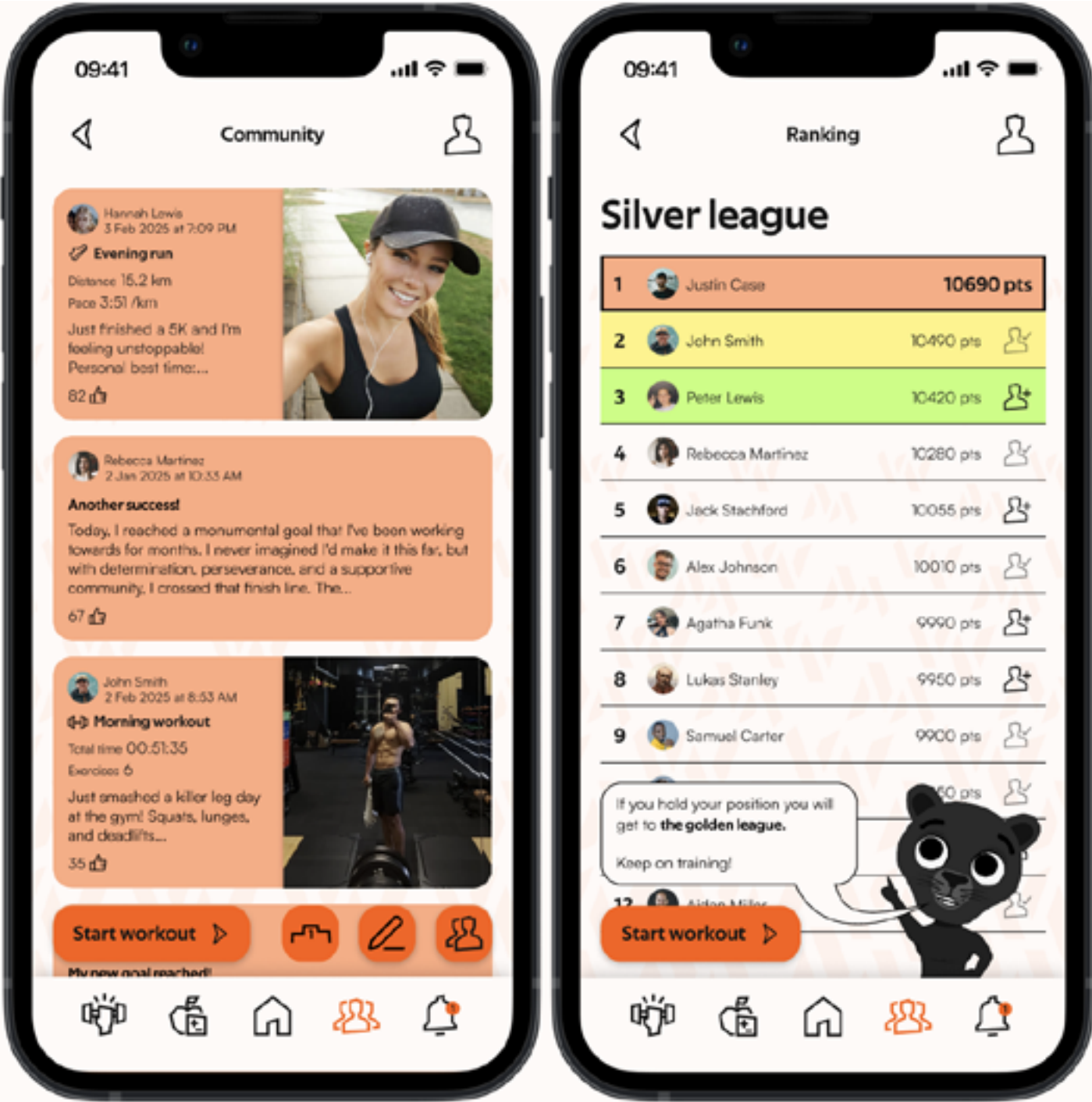
“I start working out, but without a plan I quickly get lost. It’d be great if the app suggested something on its own.”



“Basic food products with approximate calories are enough — it’s better to have a rough estimate than guess blindly, especially when eating out.”

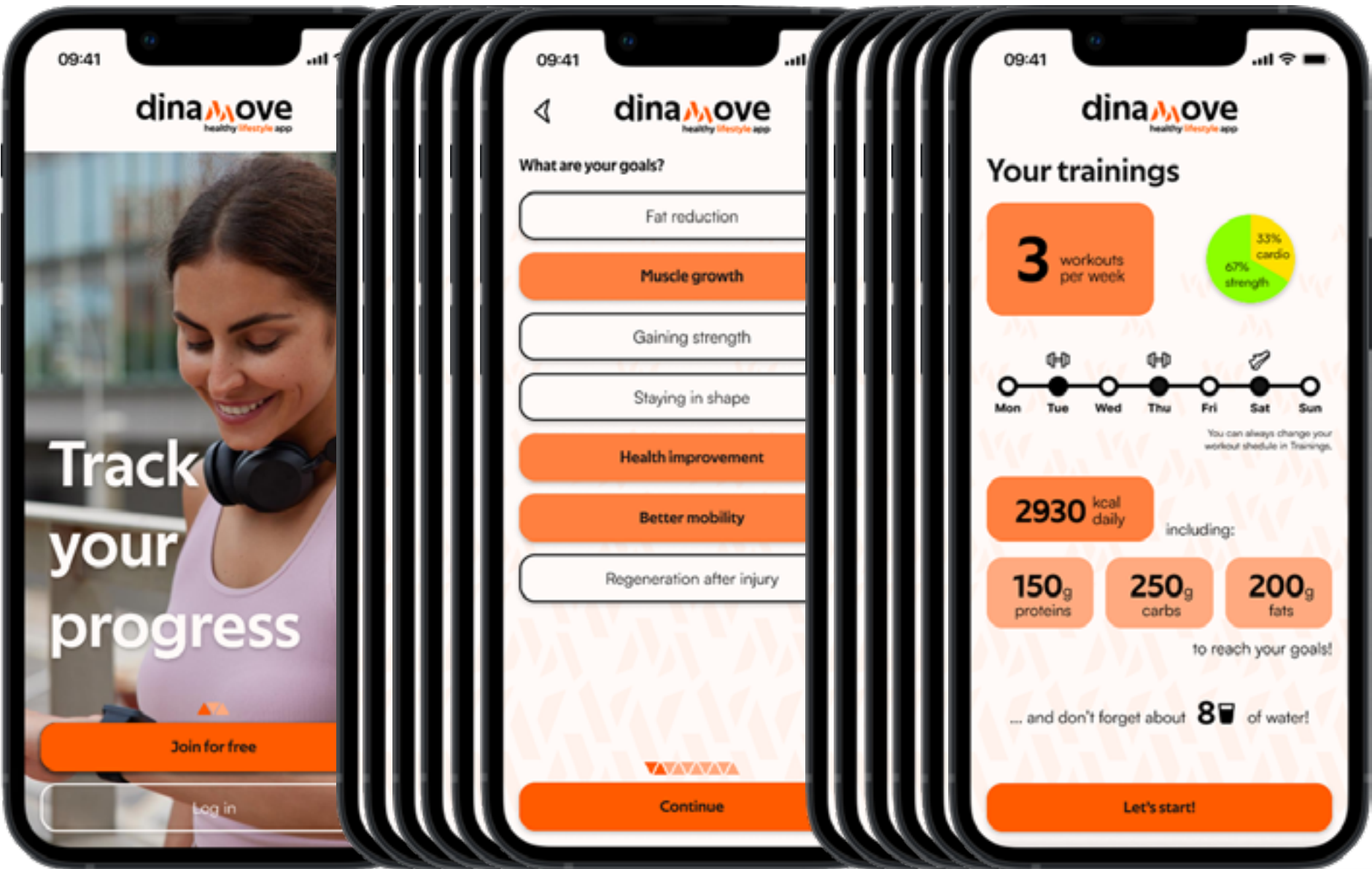


“It’s nice to see that others are working out too — it somehow motivates me even more.”



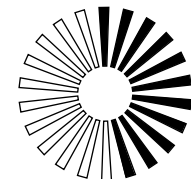
Personalized onboarding, step by step

The onboarding process was intentionally split into 10 lightweight screens to avoid overwhelming the user with too much content at once. Each step has a clear context and flows smoothly into the next — the user is guided step by step. It’s not just about collecting data, but the first moment of building a relationship with the app.



Minimum steps, maximum clarity

After launching the app, the user moves through it intuitively — I made sure actions are quick and easy to understand. User flows were simplified and the interface doesn’t distract. This way, the user can focus on doing, not on searching for options.



Consistent and aesthetic UI

I designed the UI in a minimalist way, with a strong focus on readability and content hierarchy. Clear color accents guide attention, while a custom icon set unifies the app's visual language.



Content hierarchy — easy-to-scan screen

WCAG Compliance Results		
Element Type	AA	AAA
Small Text	✓ Pass	✓ Pass
Large Text	✓ Pass	✓ Pass
UI Components	✓ Pass	✓ Pass

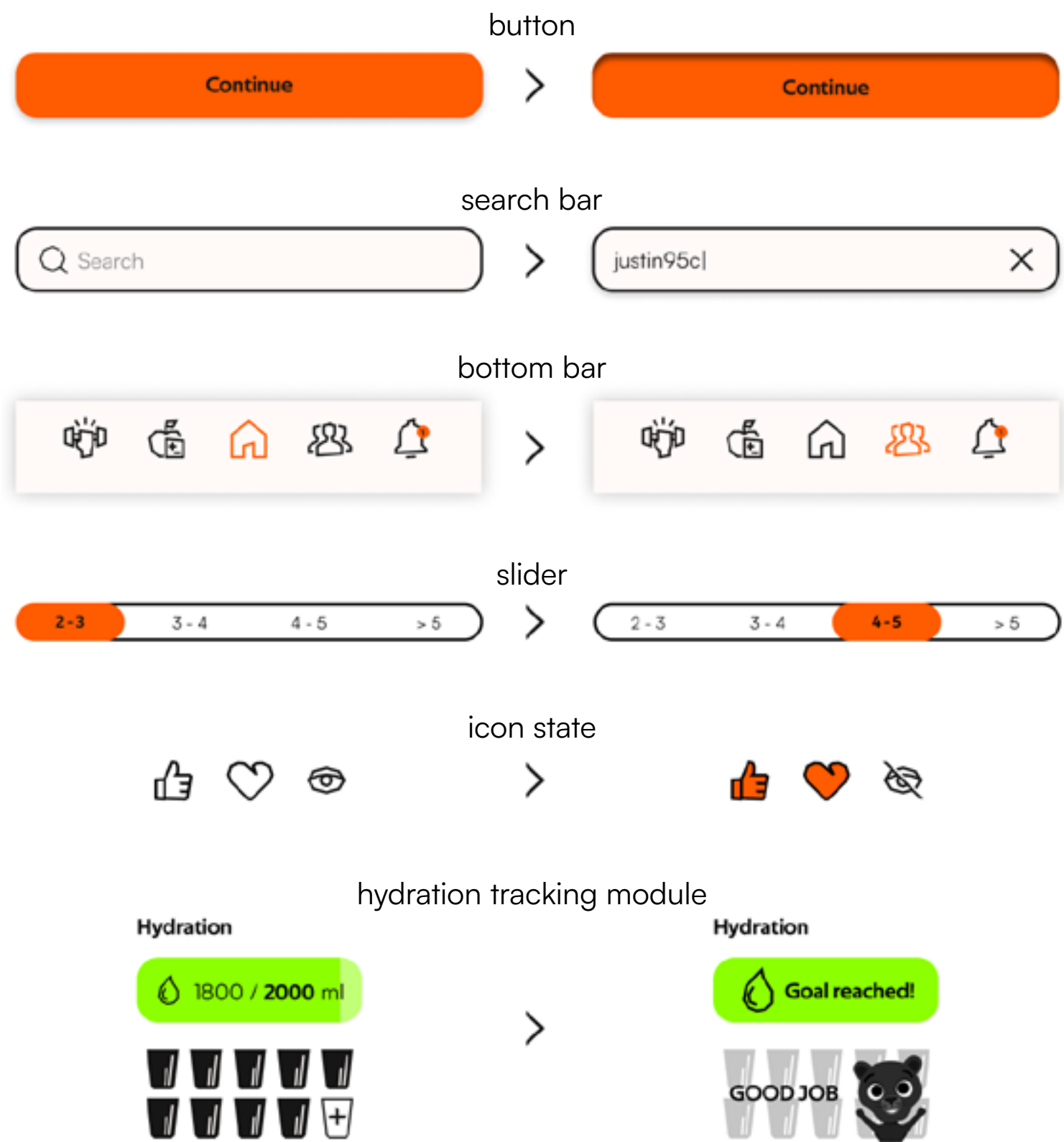
Colors — consistent with branding and verified with a contrast checker



Custom icon set — unique application character

Animations and micro-interactions

I decided to add micro-interactions as early as the first iteration to test their impact on the app's reception — after all, thanks to them, Dinamove provides the user with smooth feedback.



Animations and app walkthrough available at the link:
<https://youtu.be/txjSBMjMzw4>



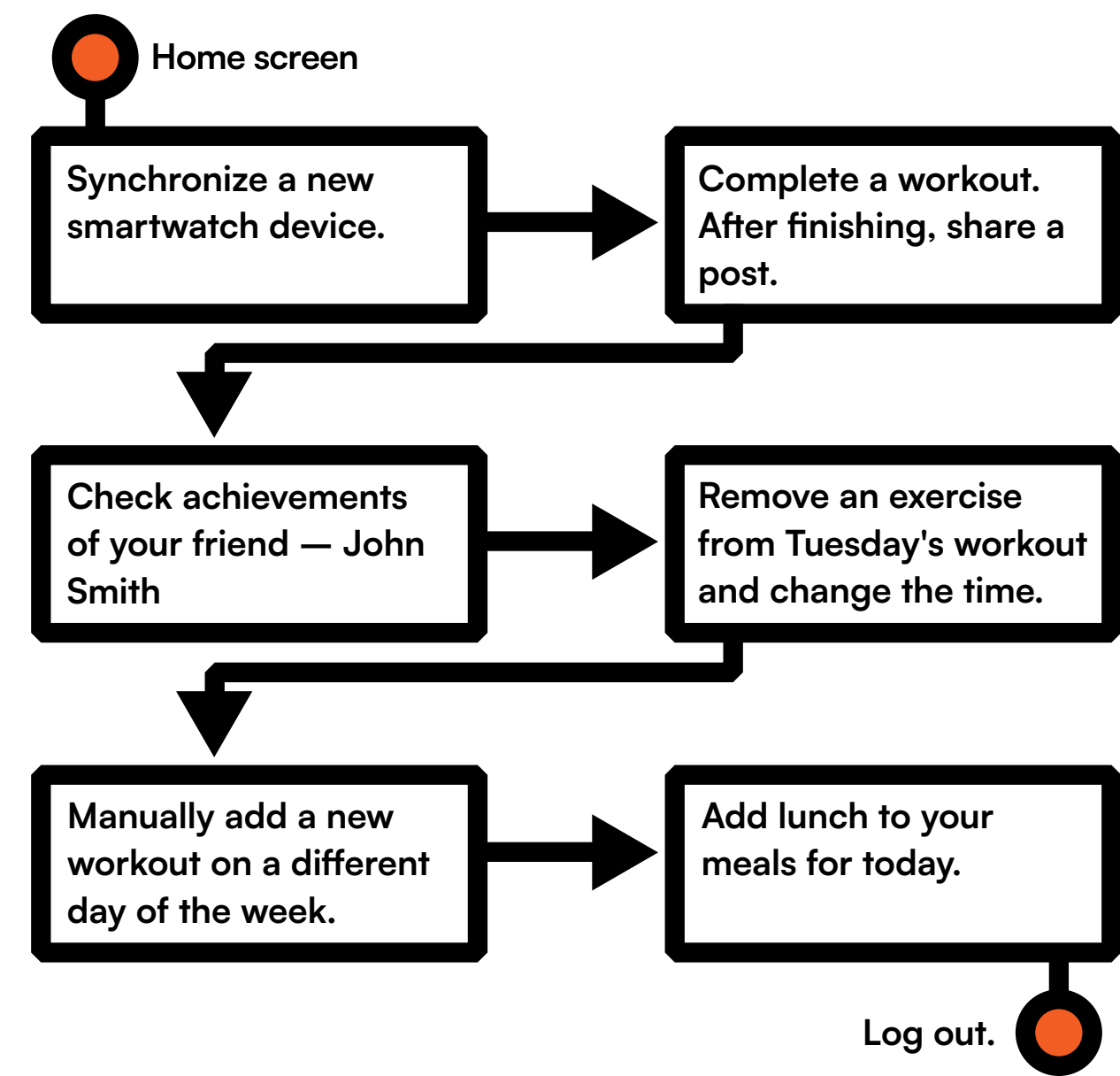
Prototype Testing

How did the usability testing go?

I conducted usability tests with 5 participants from the target group. Each participant had 7 tasks to complete — some were repeated across users to double-check key or potentially problematic areas in the app.

I recorded the sessions (video + audio) and measured time-on-task, which allowed for a detailed analysis of how the interface was used. I paid close attention to moments of hesitation — instances of users actually getting lost were rare.

At the end, everyone filled out a short survey rating their experience and satisfaction.



What are the outcomes?

The tests allowed me to see which elements work according to assumptions and which raise doubts for users. Although there weren't many errors, moments of hesitation pointed to specific areas requiring refinement.

evaluation criteria = effectiveness + efficiency + satisfaction

- ✓ few instances of users "getting lost" — actions were performed as expected, sometimes with brief hesitation
- ✓ custom icons proved legible and recognizable in the context of navigation, placement, and function
- ✓ onboarding — users understood the sequential stages and didn't feel overwhelmed
- ✓ gamification was well-received — points, rewards, and feedback were noticed and appreciated by the audience

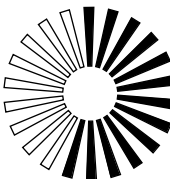
- ✗ ...but the mascot could be present even more often
- ✗ arrow touch targets (hitboxes) in date/unit components were too small, causing clicking difficulties
- ✗ some workout descriptions were too long, and participants needed more time to read and understand instructions
- ✗ additional contextual buttons in the social section above the bottom bar were not always noticed

What's next?

Due to the research nature of the project, it is impossible to explicitly define the prototype's business impact, so the added value lies in the final conclusions and insights regarding gamification implementation. If I had the opportunity to work with a larger group, I would definitely expand the concept with **A/B testing** between a highly gamified variant and a simplified one.

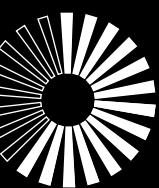
A step forward would be subsequent iterations of the design and research process based on errors caught in the previous stage and adding more innovative ideas. From this point, I would like to expand the research methodology to include, e.g., **eye-tracking** and **heatmaps**.

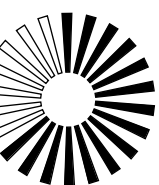
Ultimately, everything comes down to people and budget.



Branding

Dinamove branding is a consistent visual and functional identity — colors, typography, and icons harmonize with the interface, creating an intuitive and more complete experience. This combination of visual strategy and UX/UI design strengthens user trust in the product.





What did this journey teach me?

Working on Dinamove showed me the importance of holistic product thinking — not just about the interface, but also about how individual elements support the user and their habits. I realized that even simple UI decisions, color selection, or the way the user is guided through onboarding, have a real impact on the overall experience.

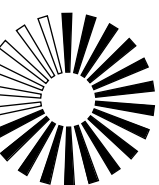
I didn't initially suspect how much behavioral psychology shapes motivation. Gamification is not a "silver bullet" — its mechanisms must be applied consciously to genuinely support the user and their habits. Implementing such tools without reflection can be harmful and lead to a dead end, which, in a real work environment, undoubtedly translates into time and financial losses.

The project also clearly demonstrated the limitations of working solo and simultaneously pointed out directions for further development.



App promo spot available
in this link:

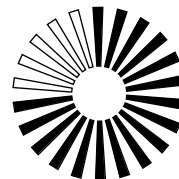
<https://youtu.be/-mpRb1o900Q>



Smart Home App

Redesign of a domestic market product

Project type: mobile application
Scope of work: design team member



Role & responsibilities

I participated in virtually every stage of the project. The team consisted of three people: a Lead Designer, myself, and another designer.

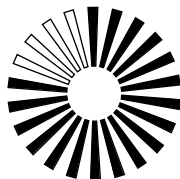
My responsibilities included designing mobile user interfaces, developing the app’s design system, creating high-fidelity wireframes, and co-facilitating UX workshops with the client. In the later stages, I worked closely with the development team to ensure implementation consistency and polish the UI details.

Project goal

Revamping a smart home management mobile app. The client expected a more intuitive, modern, and consistent interface that would better reflect the system's complexity while remaining simple for the end user.

Key challenges

- Lack of visual and interaction consistency between app modules,
- difficult, unintuitive navigation and management of multiple smart home functions,
- high client expectations for a modern, scalable design system, while maintaining simplicity for the user.



Design Process

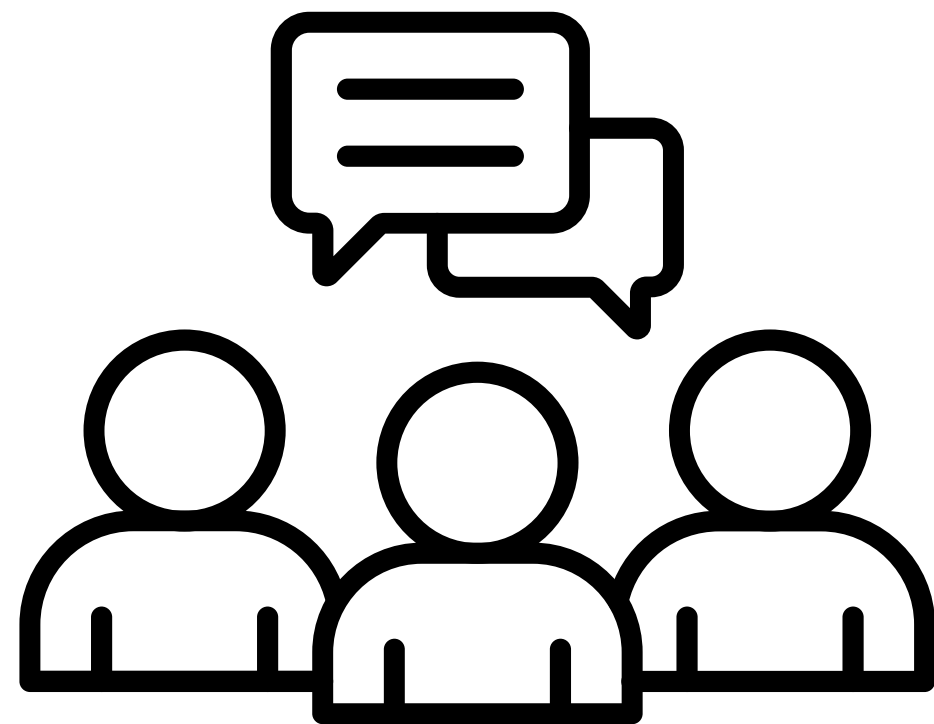
Client workshops

During the initial meetings with the client and their decision-making team, we conducted a walkthrough of the entire application — from the simplest functions to the most complex use cases. We discussed the strengths and weaknesses of the current interface and jointly determined which features were mission-critical and which could be simplified or rebuilt. We also discussed typical user paths and existing pain points.

A key moment of the workshops was an exercise using a card divided into four sections: strengths, weaknesses, fears, and expectations. This tool engaged both sides — both the client's team and us as designers — allowing us to quickly gather diverse perspectives, identify priorities, and visually organize the findings.

Key takeaways from the workshops and exercises:

- navigation fails in more complex scenarios,
- aesthetics date back 15 years, skeuomorphic design,
- unctional priorities were established.



Design phase

After gathering insights from the workshops and UX exercises, we proceeded to design the new interfaces. We started with user flows and low-fidelity wireframes, which allowed for quick idea verification.

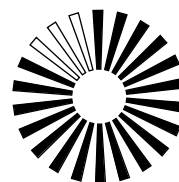
The next step was developing high-fidelity wireframes and prototypes, incorporating the established priorities. The iterative process allowed us to quickly test ideas within the team, verify them weekly with the client, and better align the final product with both business needs and user expectations.



Each team member prepared their own visual proposal. My concept, leaning towards neumorphism and dark colors, was appreciated, but...

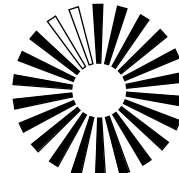


..ultimately was not implemented — the decision to choose the most minimalist variant possible was made in alignment with the client's needs.



Final Effect

The final UI was designed with a focus on readability, intuitiveness, and visual consistency. The mobile screens and tablet version form a cohesive system, ensuring a seamless user experience across different devices.



Device Pairing



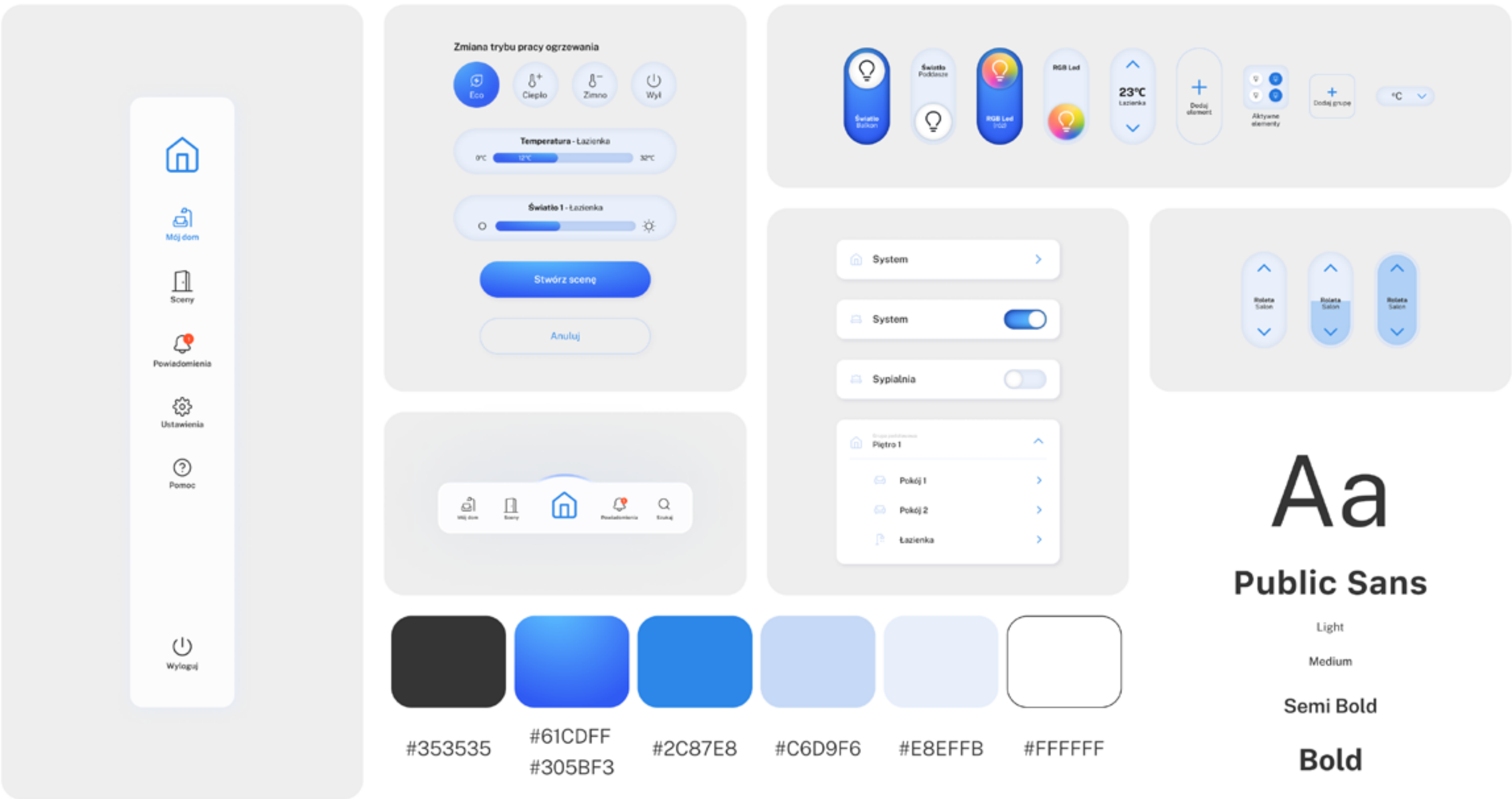
Dark Mode



Design System

The design system focuses on component consistency, visual hierarchy, typography, and color palette, facilitating product scalability and future updates. Animations and micro-interactions were kept to a minimum — sufficient to highlight interaction states and support the user without distraction.

The project was developed in close collaboration with the development team, allowing us to refine interaction details and ensure the final product is both aesthetic and fully functional. As a result, the design system and interfaces are ready for further development and easy implementation in future product iterations.



Conclusions

The design process highlighted the importance of team collaboration, exchanging ideas, and being open to business decisions. Every stage — from UX workshops, through visual experiments, to the final design system — was an opportunity to learn and verify my own ideas in practice. Thanks to this project, I also realized that even simple decisions in the UI and design system have a real impact on the User Experience, while usability testing and iterations allow for identifying moments of hesitation and improving overall usability.

